

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

BANKEY BIHARI TEMPLE, VRINDAVAN, UTTAR PRADESH

In order to relish India's sacred geography, one must perhaps try and find joy in folklore before looking for logic. The story of Tansen's guru, Swami Haridas, is a case in point. Surrounded by devotees in Vrindavan, the poet-musician was once singing a couplet in praise of Radha and Krishna. Impressed by his fervour, the couple is said to have appeared in front of him and granted him a boon. Haridas said he wanted to see them as one. The divine bodies merged to create the black idol of Bankey Bihari.

Rituals at this temple are both odd and endearing. The brilliant eyes of Bankey Bihari, it is believed, can leave his devotees unconscious, so the curtain before him is open and shut intermittently. You won't hear temple bells in the morning as priests think it rude to wake up their boyish god with a start.

WHAT ELSE TO DO

While Vrindavan is home to several beautiful temples—the Krishna Balram Mandir, the Goswami temples—Mathura and its sumptuous street food is only a half-hour drive away.

LINGARAJ TEMPLE, BHUBANESWAR, ODISHA

Tasked with destruction and preservation, respectively, Shiva and Vishnu often inhabit very different worlds. But several Hindu texts hint at a bonhomie between them. A manifestation of that can be found at Bhubaneshwar's Lingaraj Temple. Here, the *lingam* is worshipped as Hari-Hara (while Hari means Vishnu, Hara is one of Shiva's earliest names). Though constructed during the 11th century, the temple's building is believed to have started in the sixth century itself.

WHAT ELSE TO DO

There are other temples in Bhubaneswar that demand a visit—Parasurameswar and Mukteswar, for instance—but the Udaygiri and Khandagiri caves can boast of yet more antiquity.



ALAMY



CHINTAMANI TEMPLE, THEUR, MAHARASHTRA

If Hindu mythology is anything to go by, Shiva's largesse often lands the world in a spot of trouble. When, for instance, the god grants Gana kingship of the three worlds, the warrior-king becomes so drunk on power that he steals from the sage Kapila his wish-granting jewel, Chintamani. Only after a violent intervention by Ganesha is the jewel returned to Kapila and peace is again restored in the world. So impressed was Ganesha by Kapila's devotion that it is believed he stayed on with him in Theur.

Even though the site at which the Chintamani Temple was built has been considered holy for centuries, it was the Peshwa rulers of the 18th century who renovated the shrine, making it one of the largest Ashtavinayaka temples. The eyes of Ganesha's *sindur*-smeared idol have been studded with jewels.

WHAT ELSE TO DO

Only 25 km from Pune, a visit to the Chintamani Temple also leaves one with a chance to visit several other travel attractions—the Aga Khan Palace, Raja Dinkar Kelkar Museum, etc.